PORTLAND | Public Schools

TOGETHER, WE RISE

Middle School Student Experience

K-8 & 6-8 Schools

Agenda

01 Current Landscape and Challenges

02 Comparing K-8 and 6-8 Experiences

03 Case Study Examples

04 Q & A

PROBLEM STATEMENT:

We are subsidizing K-8 middle grades programs with 21 FTE to ensure core programming.

Students across different middle grade models face inequitable access to high-quality programming, specialized educators, elective pathways, support services, extracurricular options, and strong educator teams.

PPS Middle Grades Redesign (2021-current)

As a result of this system-wide work, the following is now true in all middle grades programs:

- Grade-level standards-aligned core curriculum
- Access to Advisory
- Standards-based grading
- Supported transitions
- Aligned schedules*

Due to variable enrollment and staffing models, the following is not yet consistent across middle grades programs:

- Enrichment & extracurricular opportunities/pathways
- Access to academic intervention and acceleration, as needed
- Collaborative teacher teams

Enrollment & Community Size Impact

Comparing Middle School Student Experiences in Portland Public Schools

K-8 Middle School Programs

77 – 234 students

KEY CHARACTERISTICS:

- Creates intimate, tightly-knit educational settings.
- Restricts available course variety.
- Limits overall staffing and scheduling flexibility.

Traditional 6-8 Middle Schools

377 – 701 students

KEY CHARACTERISTICS:

- Larger student body cohorts and community scale.
- Supports robust, comprehensive course variety.
- Enables staffing flexibility and specialized roles.

K-8 Middle Grades Staffing Subsidy

K-8 School	6-8 Enrollment	Actual 6-8 Teacher FTE in a K-8	Formula 6-8 Teacher FTE in a Comprehensive MS	Difference (FTE subsidy)	Cost Difference ($ subsidy)
ACCESS	161	8.9	7	**1.9**	**$304,000**
Astor	146	8.4	6.4	**2**	**$320,000**
Beverly Cleary	191	9.8	8.2	**1.6**	**$256,000**
Bridger CSS	131	8.4	5.6	**2.8**	**$448,000**
Cesar Chavez	147	9.2	7.4	**1.8**	**$288,000**
Faubion	209	10.8	10	**0.8**	**$128,000**
Laurelhurst	226	12	9.8	**2.2**	**$352,000**
MLC 6-8	136	8.4	5.8	**2.6**	**$416,000**
Odyssey	81	4.4	3.6	**0.8**	**$128,000**
Skyline	73	4.4	3.2	**1.2**	**$192,000**
Sunnyside	186	8.4	8	**0.4**	**$64,000**
Vernon	181	8.8	7.8	**1**	**$160,000**
Winterhaven	149	8.4	6.4	**2**	**$320,000**
Total	**2,017**	**110.3**	**89.2**	**21.1**	**$3,376,000**

6-8 Middle School Staffing and Cost Per Pupil

For General 6-12 Instructor FTE, not all funds nor positions

6-8 School	Enrollment	Teacher FTE	6-12 Instructor $ per Student
Beaumont	413	17.6	$6,818.40
Brentwood	427	19.2	$7,194.38
da Vinci	430	18.4	$6,846.51
George	374	17	$7,272.73
Gray	432	18.4	$6,814.81
Harriet Tubman	438	19.6	$7,159.82
Harrison Park	440	19.8	$7,200.00
Hosford	519	22	$6,782.27
Jackson	693	29.4	$6,787.88
Kellogg	515	23	$7,145.63
Mt. Tabor	415	17.6	$6,785.54
Ockley Green	436	19.6	$7,192.66
Roseway Heights	560	24.8	$7,085.71
Sellwood	537	22.8	$6,793.30
West Sylvan	654	27.8	$6,801.22
Totals	**7283**	**317**	**$6,964.16**

Cost Per Pupil

K-8 Avg cost per student

~ $8,750

6-8 Avg cost per student

~ $7,000

Difference per student

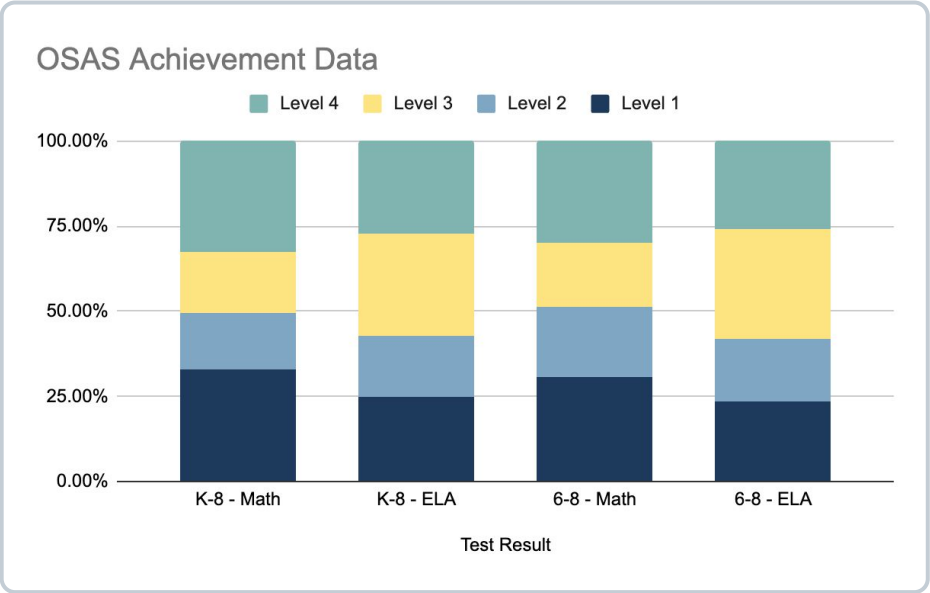
~ $1,750

Outcomes: OSAS

Academic outcomes, measured by OSAS results, do not show significant differences between 6-8 and K-8 schools.

This aligns with national research:

> "NWREL looked at the available research on grade configuration and concluded that little evidence existed to determine a cause-and-effect relationship between grade configuration and academic achievement."
>
> (Education NW, 2011)



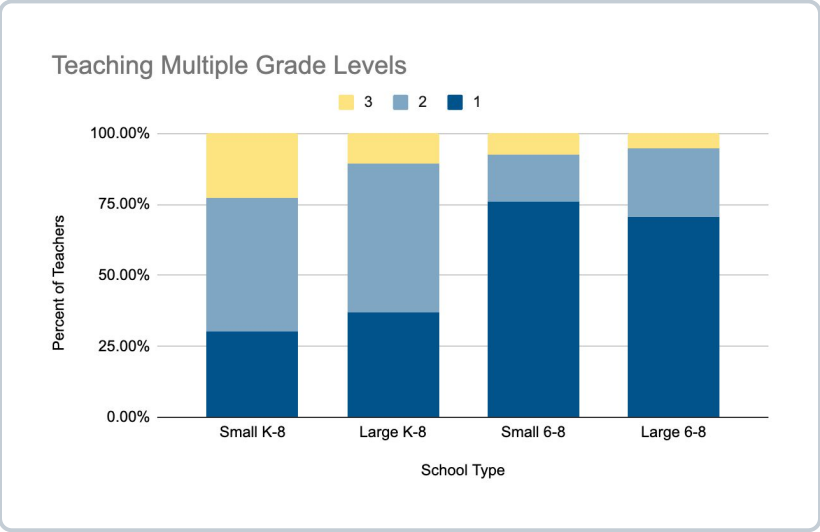
Four PPS Case Studies: An Overview

Small K-8 School 131 6th-8th students, 27% HU	Large K-8 School 226 6th-8th students, 17% HU	Small 6-8 School 418 students, 14% HU	Large 6-8 School 534 students, 21% HU
STAFFING **8.4 teachers** (1-6 preps)	STAFFING **12 teachers** (1-6 preps)	STAFFING **25 teachers** (1-5 preps)	STAFFING **29 teachers** (1-5 preps)
ELECTIVES **9 elective options**	ELECTIVES **15 elective options**	ELECTIVES **20 elective options**	ELECTIVES **25 elective options**
WORLD LANGUAGES **No languages**	WORLD LANGUAGES **Spanish**	WORLD LANGUAGES **Spanish & DLI program**	WORLD LANGUAGES **Spanish**
ADVANCED MATH **Algebra 1-2 & Project Based Math**	ADVANCED MATH **Algebra 1-2 & Compacted Math**	ADVANCED MATH **Algebra 1-2 & Compacted Math**	ADVANCED MATH **Algebra 1-2 & Compacted Math**
INTERVENTIONS **No intervention courses**	INTERVENTIONS **Math & literacy intervention**	INTERVENTIONS **MS intervention course**	INTERVENTIONS **Math & 2 literacy intervention**

Educator Assignments & Teaming Opportunities

In our K-8 case studies, **~75%** of teachers teach **more than one grade level**.

In our 6-8 case studies, **~75%** of teachers teach **just one grade level**.



Teacher “Preps” or Content Assignments

(Small K-8 example)

Teacher A	Middle School Success			
Teacher B	Leadership			
Teacher C	Art 6, 2 sections	Art: Intermediate		
Teacher D	Music Foundations, 2 sections	Drumming		
Teacher E	Social Sciences A, 2 sections	Language Arts 6, 2 sections	Creative Writing 6-8	Yearbook
Teacher F	Social Sciences C, 2 sections	Social Sciences B, 2 sections	Health 7	Physical Ed 7
Teacher G	Health 8 2 sections Physical Ed 7	Health 7 Physical Ed 6, 2 sections	Health 6, 2 sections Physical Ed 8, 2 sections	
Teacher H	Math 6: Common Core, 2 sections	Integrated Science 6, 2 sections	Project Based Math 8	
Teacher I	Integrated Science 8, 2 sections	Integrated Science 7, 2 sections	Project Green	
Teacher J	Language Arts 8, 2 sections	Language Arts 7, 2 sections	Middle School Success	
Teacher K	Math 7: Common Core, 2 sections	Math 8: Common Core	Algebra 1-2	Project Based Math 8
Teacher L	Integrated ELD			

Elective Offerings (Large 6-8 example)

Leadership / Success

Leadership
Middle School Success
Teacher Aide

Visual Art

3D Art: Advanced
3D Art: Intermediate
Art 6
Art 7
Art 8
Art: Advanced
Art: Ceramics Advanced
Art: Ceramics Beginning
Art: Textiles Advanced
Art: Textiles Intermediate

Performing Arts

Band: Beginning
Band: Intermediate
Band: Advanced

Other

Creative Writing
Explore Film
Journalism
Project Green
STEM - Engineering
STEM - Technology
STEM - Technology 2
STEM Elective
STEM Elective 2

Language

Intro to Spanish
Spanish 1-2

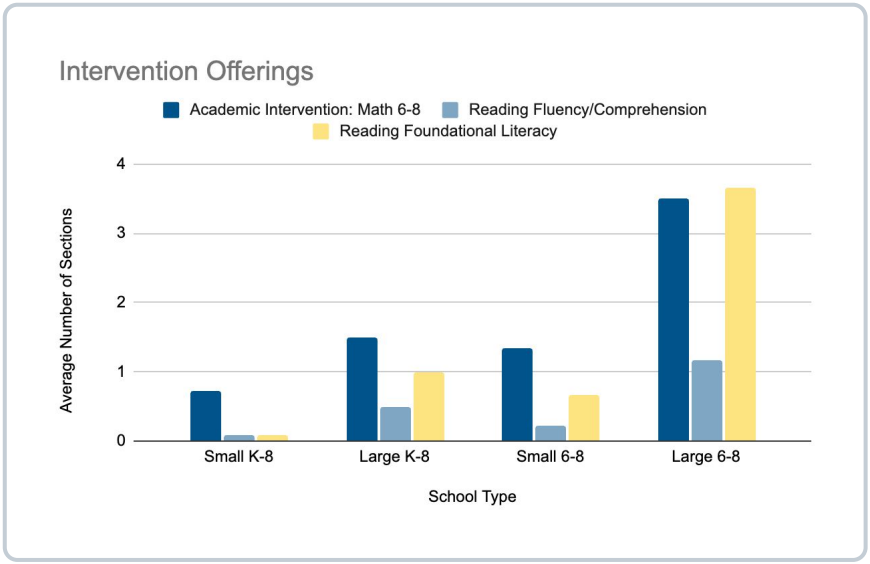
Elective Offerings (Small K-8 example)

Leadership / Success	Visual Art	Performing Arts	Other	Language
Middle School Success	Art 6	Music Foundations	Creative Writing 6-8	*No languages offered*
Leadership	Art: Intermediate	Drumming	Yearbook	
			Project Green	

Opportunities for Targeted Academic Intervention

Due to low student numbers, smaller **K-8 schools** frequently cannot staff targeted academic intervention courses, leaving eligible students without necessary support.

Larger **6-8 schools** have greater capacity to staff targeted intervention courses for students in need of this support.



Summary and Questions

- We are currently using 21 non-formula FTE or **~$3 million** to supplement middle school programming in K-8 buildings.
- Educators in K-8 buildings and 6-8 buildings have disparate work loads and access to collaborative educator teams.
- Middle grades students in K-8 buildings and 6-8 buildings have disparate access to specialized educators, elective pathways, and intervention opportunities.
- The proposed scenarios expand access to comprehensive middle school programming, reduce non-formula FTE subsidies, and free up space for well-resourced elementary programs.